NO. 161 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 13 NOVEMBER 2026



THIRTY-THREE YEARS, NO BOARD CHAIR, AND NO REASON IN THE FILING (P3)

THE WORLD

Jensen Huang resigns from Nvidia with no reason given, and the board names its first chair

TECHNOLOGY

Wyden and Neal call the 25 per cent chip tariff an unconstitutional export tax

THE LONG READ

Japan moves the school club out of the school, and Kobe charges ¥3,200 a month

Source: Office of the President, Republic of China (Taiwan), CC BY 2.0. Jensen Huang at the first K.T. Li Award ceremony, 9 November 2023.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 161

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THE SPINE: THE NAME ON THE DOOR. Nvidia had no board chair for thirty-three years because its founder was the institution, and the market has now priced him (p3); Megaspeed's office at Collyer Quay was locked, its director of record holds one share bought for a dollar (p5); a tariff written for keeping things out is letting them through (p7); the famous names on leather goods say in their own filings that they touch none of it (p6); and in Japan the school club has changed its legal name and nothing else — 94.2 per cent of "community" clubs still meet in the school (p22).

FROM THE DESK

"An institution is the lengthened shadow of one man; as Monachism, of the hermit Antony..."

Ralph Waldo Emerson, "Self-Reliance", *Essays: First Series* (1841). Read at source in the Project Gutenberg text.[1]

For p3, where a four-trillion-dollar company turns out to have had no chair in thirty-three years, and p21, where the shadow is being asked to pay rent.

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.869%	▲ 14.2bp
US 10-year[2]	5.129%	▲ 12.3bp
VWRA[3]	$189.50	▼ 0.06%
AGGU[3]	$5.80	▼ 0.14%
Gold[3]	$3,876.14	▼ 2.80%
Bitcoin[3]	~$71,390	▼ 3.9%
Dollar index[3]	103.17	▲ 0.24%
USD/SGD[3]	1.2873	▲ 0.25%
Straits Times[3]	5,282.70	▼ 0.13%

Brent is held, not printed: three sources gave $96.12, $104.62 and about $91.70 for the same session (p12). Not advice.[3]

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FRIDAY

Years Jensen Huang ran Nvidia: **33** — p3

Chairs its board had in those years: **0** — p3

Reasons for his resignation given in the filing: **0** — p3

Dollars of market value gone since Friday: **740,000,000,000** — p3

Tankers Iran says burned on mines, and vessels it has named: **3 / 0** — p4

Under investigation over Megaspeed, and in Singapore: **6 / 0** — p5

Singapore dollars paid for the share she took on leaving: **1** — p5

Per cent of the chips' value the tariff takes: **25** — p7

Dollars of it traced to a White House ballroom: **26,000,000** — p7

Versions of Nvidia's fastest card at one British shop, and with a price: **27 / 1** — p8

Pounds for 32 gigabytes on that card, against $6,799 for 192: **6,999.98** — p8

Dollars for the eyewear frame, and in progressive lenses: **395 / 725** — p9

Per cent probability the market gave a December hold: **0** — p12

Signals the hobby has identified: **594** — p15

Signals it cannot name: **408** — p15

Yen a month the state says a Japanese club should cost: **1,000–3,000** — p21

Per cent of Japan's "community" clubs meeting in the school: **94.2** — p22

SOURCES 1 Ralph Waldo Emerson, "Self-Reliance", in *Essays: First Series*, 1841 — **the sentence read at source** in Project Gutenberg eBook 16643. 2 Investing.com's own bond-yield pages at the close of Thursday 12 November, **read at source** and cross-checked against CNBC's levels of the same day to within a basis point (p12). 3 Each level read at its own quote page on 12 November and set out with its sourcing on p12; **none of those pages prints a calendar date, so the session was anchored by cross-check; bitcoin is approximate because its quote page does not reconcile its own figures; and Brent is held because three sources disagreed by thirteen dollars.** Every number in The Meridian Index is sourced on the page it cites.

THE WORLD · NVIDIA & WASHINGTON

Jensen Huang resigns as Nvidia's chief executive, effective immediately

Colette Kress, the finance chief, takes the job on an interim basis and Harvey Jones becomes Nvidia's first board chair. More than US$740bn of market value has gone since Friday's close.

Nvidia told the Securities and Exchange Commission on Thursday 12 November that its board had accepted the resignation of Jensen Huang as president, chief executive and director, effective immediately. Colette Kress, 59, finance chief since September 2013, is interim chief executive and keeps the finance job; Harvey Jones, 73, a director since 1993, becomes the first chair the company has ever had.[1]

Nvidia designs the processors on which almost all the world's machine-learning work is done — about nine-tenths of the advanced market — and until last week it was the most valuable listed company on earth. The founder who ran it for thirty-three years went in four days, and not because the business turned: revenue has gone from $4.13bn in 2014 to $215.9bn in the 2026 financial year. The reason is private, and Washington has made it a security matter.[2]

Huang had written to staff on 8 November admitting an affair and apologising to his family. American intelligence had assessed that one of the women was working for China's state security service — a judgement that Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, put in a memo in the spring, NBC News reports. On Sunday the board said it had "no reason to believe" that national security or company secrets had been compromised.[3]

The filing says none of that. Item 5.02 records the resignation and the two appointments and gives no reason, no disagreement and no separation terms. The shares fell as much as 14 per cent on Thursday and closed down 4.34 per cent, just above a four-trillion-dollar valuation: a sixth straight weekly fall, the longest run since 2012. Results stand at Tuesday 17 November. Brian Mast, who chairs House Foreign Affairs, says Huang will testify before Thanksgiving, and a subpoena follows if that slips.[4]

BEIJING — GLOBAL TIMES

The state paper reads the exit as American politics eating its own champion. The foreign ministry's **Mao Ning** calls the espionage allegation "purely unsubstantiated and directed at smearing China". **Xiang Ligang** of the Beijing Institute of Intelligent Era Industry argues Huang may be the scapegoat if the American AI wager disappoints.[5]

NEW DELHI — WION

The Indian read is supply, not scandal: buyers who cannot depend on one vendor go looking, and export curbs have already "helped competitors build stronger customer and developer ecosystems in China". **Moore Threads**, **MetaX** and **Cambricon** each rose a tenth.[6]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE DESKS PRICED INTO JENSEN HUANG

Ten analysts turned more bearish on Nvidia inside a week, by FactSet's count, and several priced the man himself. **Dan Ives**: "Nvidia's value is $300 per share with Jensen as CEO and $225 per share without". **Mark Lipacis** of Evercore, cutting from $465 to $186: "Nvidia has no obvious succession plan or number 2 operational executive". **Lindsey Stewart** of Morningstar: "an unconventional governance structure can become a source of risk... for investors". Bernstein cut $400 to $200.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · NVIDIA WITHOUT JENSEN HUANG

The case against this page is that the market has confused a man with a production line. Simon Leopold of Raymond James: "The market reaction to the resignation of Nvidia's CEO suggests Jensen Huang was a one-man-band; he was not." **Cody Acree** of StoneX sees "no impact to revenue or EPS estimates through at least 2028". First-half revenue was $96bn, up 85 per cent.[8]

SOURCES 1 Nvidia's Form 8-K, accession 0001045810-26-000082, period of report 11 November 2026, filed 12 November, Items 5.02 and 9.01 — **read at source on EDGAR**, as was Exhibit 99.1, the company's own transition release. 2 Al Jazeera, 12 November, for the share of advanced AI chips and the revenue run. 3 Huang's staff memo of 8 November as Anadolu Agency reproduces it, **paraphrased here rather than quoted**; NBC News, 12 November, for the Rubio memo — **NBC says plainly it has not independently verified the second-relationship reporting**; Fortune, 11 November, for the board's Sunday statement. **The New York Times, the Wall Street Journal, Reuters and the Associated Press all refused this desk, so their findings are relayed through outlets that carry them, and flagged.** 4 The 8-K as above; CNBC, 12 November, for the close, the intraday low, the weekly run and Mast's subpoena warning; Al Jazeera for the Trump posts. 5 Global Times, Beijing, 13 November, 01:05 local. 6 WION, New Delhi, 12 November, 22:56 India time. 7 CNBC's analyst round-up of 12 November and Investing.com's reaction round-up of the same day. 8 Both round-ups as above; Fortune for the first-half revenue.

HORMUZ · THREE TANKERS IN TWO DAYS

Iran says three tankers burned on mines east of the Strait of Hormuz

Tehran's army named President Trump "primarily responsible" on 12 November. It has named no vessel, flag or owner, and no outside body has confirmed a mine.

Iran's army said on Wednesday 11 November that a "violating" oil tanker had caught fire before dawn east of the Strait of Hormuz, and on Thursday that two more had burned after striking naval mines in the same water. The ships ignored warnings and switched off their radar, it said, and their owners had been misled by Washington.[1]

Every element of that comes from one government. There are no vessel names, no flags, no cargoes, no casualty figures, and no navy, insurer or registry has confirmed a strike. What exists independently is thinner: the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre logged a tanker incident on the Wednesday and said crew, damage and environmental effect were unknown.[2]

The oil price took it calmly, which is evidence of a kind. Brent for January rose 0.64 per cent to $92.08 at 0757 Greenwich time on 11 November. A market that believed the world's most important oil chokepoint had been mined three times in forty-eight hours does not move sixty cents.[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW HORMUZ IS BEING READ

The shipping trade's reflex is to wait for a hull number. Iran's framing moved in a day, from navigation safety on Wednesday to naming the American president on Thursday. Washington said in August it had cleared the strait's traffic lanes after finding more than a hundred suspected mines, so the question is not whether mines are there but whose they are.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY HORMUZ IS NOT ON PAGE THREE

This desk has no second source for any part of the Iranian account. Three tanker fires in two days in the Strait of Hormuz, all announced by the claimant, none with a named ship, is a claim about an event rather than the event. **What would settle it:** a vessel name from the maritime trade centre, an insurer's casualty notice, or an image of a hull.[2]

ABU DHABI · A PRISONER DEAL, NO CEASEFIRE

Russia and Ukraine agree a prisoner exchange in Abu Dhabi; the war goes on

Jared Kushner calls it "the biggest humanitarian release of prisoners". No headcount is fixed; Zelenskyy's negotiators discussed 1,000 to 1,500 a side.

Two days of American-mediated talks in Abu Dhabi — nearly four hours on 10 November, just under two on 11 November — ended with Russia and Ukraine agreeing in principle to a large prisoner exchange and to nothing else. Jared Kushner put it plainly: "there's no trust right now between the sides." Alexander Zorin of Russia's general staff said the swap could happen within two or three weeks.[4]

No number is fixed and this desk is not printing one: President Zelenskyy said on 10 November his negotiators had discussed a thousand a side, possibly fifteen hundred. Kushner and Steve Witkoff flew to Moscow on 12 November, then to Dublin, where forty-seven states met that day for the European Political Community.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Antalya. Turkiye signed ten loans worth **$5.1bn** with four development banks on the climate summit's fourth day. Against that, 119 countries have asked the adaptation fund for **$2.8bn** and its first round holds about **$350m**.[6]

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. At least **10** police officers were killed in an attack on their convoy on 11 November.[7]

SOURCES 1 Xinhua, 11 November, for the first fire; Anadolu's anews, 12 November 18:30, for Thursday's two and the attribution to President Trump. **Every element rests on Iran's own army statements; this desk found no independent confirmation and flags it on the page.** 2 Anadolu Energy, citing the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre's Wednesday advisory. 3 Anadolu Energy, 11 November, for the crude level, **read at source**; the August clearance figure is as the public record of the 2026 Hormuz campaign carries it. 4 PBS NewsHour, 11 November, for the session lengths and the Kushner and Zorin quotations. 5 Euronews, 11 November, for Zelenskyy's range and the Moscow and Dublin legs; An Garda Siochana's advisory of 3 November for the Dublin date. **A circulating figure of 314 prisoners belongs to the February 2026 exchange and is not printed.** 6 Al-Monitor, 12 November, for the loans; Inside Climate News, 10 November, for the adaptation fund. **Al-Monitor's paywall cut the rest of the loan breakdown.** 7 A single Xinhua-sourced wire digest of 11 November carries both items and **they are flagged single-sourced accordingly.**

SINGAPORE · THE MEGASPEED FILE

Singapore bars Alice Huang from re-entry and says Washington gave little help

The Ministry of Home Affairs says the police found insufficient evidence of an offence, returned her passport on 26 February and issued a stern warning. Four parties have been charged since February 2025.

Singapore's Ministry of Home Affairs said on Thursday 12 November that the police had closed their case against Alice Huang, the former managing director of the Singapore-registered computing firm Megaspeed, having found "insufficient evidence to establish that Huang had committed any offences". She was given a stern warning, barred from re-entering Singapore, handed back her passport on 26 February and left the country that day.[1]

The name matters because of where it surfaced this week: Huang is the executive whose relationship with Nvidia's chief executive became the security question that ended his career on Wednesday night (p3). Her company was registered here, in an office on Collyer Quay that reporters found shut. The ministry was blunt that she was never investigated for espionage, and that she is a Hong Kong resident, not a Singapore one.[1]

The sharper line is about the Americans. Singapore says it raised cooperation over Supermicro with United States authorities on 7 July 2025 and repeated its requests to the Justice Department and the Federal Bureau of Investigation from September 2025, receiving "limited information or assistance in respect of the company". A government routinely told it is the leak in the chip chain has said on the record that it asked for help and did not get it.[2]

The enforcement that did happen is almost entirely offshore. American export inspectors ran a post-shipment verification at Megaspeed on 24 June 2025, with Huang present, and the police interviewed her that day. Four individuals and companies have been charged between February 2025 and July 2026, including for fraud by false representation over server purchases. Megaspeed and six other individuals remain under investigation — and **none of those six has been in Singapore since it opened**.[1]

6

STILL UNDER INVESTIGATION; NONE OF THEM IN SINGAPORE

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE READ INTO THE HUANG STATEMENT

On the local boards the bar on Alice Huang was not the story. The Home Affairs thread drew 145 replies overnight; the one that found its own traffic within three hours was the New York Times headline saying Singapore had found Washington unhelpful on Megaspeed. Readers here have spent a year being told their city is the back door.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · INSUFFICIENT EVIDENCE ON A S$1 SHARE

The uncomfortable reading of the same statement: twenty months of investigation has produced charges against four parties, six further people who all stay abroad, and a closed file on the one executive who was physically here. Megaspeed's filings show Huang received **one share for S$1** on the day she stepped down after eight months. Senator Tom Cotton has separately asked the American commerce secretary to investigate the firm as a spin-off of a Chinese state-owned cloud company — **a letter this desk did not open at source and does not quote**.[4]

ALSO IN SINGAPORE

Health. The Health Ministry named **six** healthcare entities hit by unauthorised system access on 12 November — the Agency for Integrated Care's advance-care-planning system, Alliance Medinet, Doctor Anywhere, Fullerton Health, Minmed and Dementia Singapore's app — and said no patient health records were accessed so far as it knows.[5]

Mental health. A consultation on young people's access to mental-health services runs to **6pm on 8 December**: one in three aged 10 to 18 report symptoms of depression or anxiety and **70 per cent** of those did not seek professional help (p14).[5]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Home Affairs' statement of 12 November 2026, quoted as the Straits Times report of it carries the text — **the ministry's own media-room page returned 404 on every path this desk tried, and the Straits Times, Channel NewsAsia and the Business Times all refuse this desk directly**, so the statement is read through its syndicated copy; NBC News, 12 November, independently confirms the bar, the stern warning, the February finding and the six further individuals. 2 NBC News, 12 November, for the 7 July meeting, the requests from September 2025 and the "limited information or assistance" wording; Newsquawk's timestamped wire of 12 November 13:41 Greenwich time for the passport date. 3 HardwareZone's EDMW boards, read 13 November, for the reply counts and which thread travelled. **Reddit refused this desk in every form, so no r/singapore sentiment appears anywhere in this issue.** 4 Megaspeed's own filings as CNBC reports them, 11 November; Senator Cotton's letter is **flagged as unread at source**. 5 The Health Ministry's own two releases of 11 and 12 November, **read at source**.

THE ATELIER · IRON KETTLES & TETSUBIN

Oigen sells a bare-iron tetsubin at ¥22,000; Suzuki Morihisa delivers in 2028

The sixteenth-generation Morihisa kettle is ¥220,000 and ships between August 2027 and February 2028. A glossy lining inside means you have bought a teapot, not a kettle.

A good iron kettle is bare metal inside, heavy for its size and carries its maker's mark; a bad one is lined with glossy enamel, light in the hand, and sold under a name belonging to no foundry.[1] The distinction is what you see inside: one goes on a flame, the other is a brewing pot that will craze if you try. The Japanese trade keeps the words apart even where sellers do not — a *tetsukyusu* is a teapot, enamel-coated inside; a *tetsubin* is a kettle, and Oigen of Oshu puts enamel only into teapots, leaving its kettle interiors as plain baked iron.[2]

The protection is therefore a process, not a coating: baking grows an oxide film, and the owner grows a mineral scale by boiling in it and never scrubbing it. Where the money goes is the mould — sand moulds are reusable and give a softer edge, clay moulds blur after one or two castings and are thrown away, which buys the crispness of the *arare* hail pattern. The other tell is weight: Oigen's one-litre kettle is **1.9 kilograms**, and light-for-its-volume is the fake's signature.[3]

THE MAKERS — WHAT THE LADDER BUYS

Oigen, Oshu, prices its *Maromi* one-litre at **¥22,000** including tax — the honest entry. **Iwachu** of Morioka starts at **¥44,000** and tops out at **¥121,000**; **Chushin Kobo** in Yamagata sells its *Natsume* at **¥38,500**. **Suzuki Morihisa** lists a sixteenth-generation kettle at **¥220,000**, shipping **August 2027 to February 2028**.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT TETSUBIN BUYERS CHASE AND FEAR

This box is weaker than it should be: the main forum returned a server error on every attempt and Reddit refuses this desk. Second-hand: buyers warn each other off marketplace listings and back "a real Oigen, Iwachu, or similar established brand", and collectors report "a lot of Chinese cast iron masquerading as Japanese". The test: no foundry mark, be suspicious.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TETSUBIN IRON-SUPPLEMENT CLAIM

The health claim does not survive its own arithmetic. The only published figure this desk found is a maker's own test — **0.05 milligrams of iron per 100 millilitres** — against a day's requirement the same company puts at about **fifteen litres**. A well-seasoned vessel also gives up less iron than a new one, so the scale every owner cultivates works against the claim. **Then the name:** Nambu Tekki is a geography — yet a **¥44,000** kettle sells as "Nambu Cast Iron", cast by an iron works in **Osaka**.[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · PICK THE NEXT CATEGORY

Wool blankets & throws — the mills still spinning their own yarn, and whether any of it makes sense here.

Track pumps & bicycle tools — the rebuildable floor pump, the gauge that lies, the tools that outlast three bicycles.

Chef's whites & work shirts — the cloth weights, and what survives a hundred industrial washes.

The Singapore verdict is a conditional no. Do not buy a bare-iron tetsubin here unless you will put it back on the flame for thirty seconds after every use. Mean humidity is **about 82 per cent** on the weather service's figure, above **90** before dawn: a kettle tipped out and left to air does not dry.[7]

SOURCES 1–2 Global Kitchen Japan's own explainer and Oigen's own finishing page and its own product listings, **read at source in Japanese**, for *suyaki*, *kamayaki*, the enamel-only-on-teapots rule, the do-not-touch-the-inside instruction and the hard-water first boil. 3 Japan Objects and the retailer Nio Teas for the clay-versus-sand mould economics, the counterfeit tells and the weight proxy; Oigen's own listing for the 1.9kg figure. **No maker publishes a wall thickness, so none is printed.** 4 Each maker's own shop — Oigen, Iwachu, Chushin Kobo and Suzuki Morihisa — **all read at source on 12 November 2026**; the Morihisa shipping window is quoted from its own pre-order page. **Iwachu's page does not state whether its prices include tax, which this desk notes rather than assumes.** 5 **teaforum.org returned a 503 with an hour's retry on every attempt and Reddit refused this desk, so every community line here is a search extract, not a post read at source, and is labelled so on the page.** Iwachu's spout mark is from a dealer listing read at source. 6 Wahei Freiz's own published test and its own arithmetic; Global Kitchen Japan's own product page for the Osaka-cast "Nambu" kettle, **read at source**. **The designation rule itself is held:** the official crafts database returned 503 twice and three government documents 403'd or were unreadable, so this desk prints the geography and not the statute. 7 The Meteorological Service Singapore's own climate page for the humidity figures and the Inland Revenue Authority's own page for the low-value threshold, **both read at source**; the drying conclusion is this desk's, drawn from the maker's own instruction. **Held:** Kikuchi Hojudo, whose site would not resolve, and any Singapore retailer, none of which could be verified.

TECHNOLOGY · THE EXPORT TAX

Wyden and Neal investigate the tariff on Nvidia's China chip sales

The two ranking Democrats call the 25 per cent levy "what appears to be an unconstitutional export tax system", and say Commerce suspended a Megaspeed inquiry after Nvidia's outreach.

Senator Ron Wyden and Representative Richard Neal wrote to the commerce secretary, Howard Lutnick, on Thursday 12 November to open an investigation into how the administration licensed and taxed sales of Nvidia's most advanced chips to Chinese buyers. Their letter is four pages long and this desk read all of it. Its first sentence names the thing it is investigating as a "scheme".[1]

The arrangement works like this, in the letter's own account. President Trump agreed that Nvidia could sell its Taiwan-made chips into China provided each shipment entered the United States first for security review and licensing. He then used a 1962 trade law written for blocking dangerous imports to charge a quarter of the value of those chips on entry — "effectively taking a cut of Nvidia's sales to China through what appears to be an unconstitutional export tax system". Congress wrote that law to keep things out. It is being used to let things through, at a price.[1]

Two specific allegations give the inquiry its teeth. The first is that the Commerce Department "approved sales to Chinese companies with government and military ties — including Chinese 'cutout' companies with no physical presence at their listed addresses". The second is that Commerce, "following outreach from Nvidia", suspended a separate investigation into Megaspeed, the Singapore-registered customer run by Alice Huang (p5). The letter also says at least **$26m** of the proceeds went toward the president's personal priorities, the White House ballroom among them.[1]

The preservation demand is the part lawyers will read twice: the Section 232 semiconductor investigation, including a report the letter says Lutnick transmitted to the president on **22 December 2025**, every Nvidia export-licence application, and all communications with or about Nvidia and Jensen Huang — citing the two obstruction statutes that carry five and twenty years. No response deadline is set.[2]

25%

OF THE CHIPS' VALUE, COLLECTED ON ENTRY

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAYS THE TARIFF BOUGHT

The sharpest count comes from **SemiAnalysis**, whose model puts **more than 1.5 gigawatts** of restricted Nvidia silicon as having reached China, before smuggling. Its authors are blunter than the sell side dares be: "We believe the US intelligence community is a large part of the push to get Jensen out of Nvidia" — labelled as their own inference, not reporting. On Hacker News the resignation drew two points; the thread that drew ninety-six was about Singapore.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE THAT NVIDIA'S SQUEEZE PREDATES THE TARIFF

Timothy Prickett Morgan of The Next Platform argues Nvidia's problem is not Washington but arithmetic. Hyperscalers are building their own accelerators at about half the cost of its stack; it is "not clear that the rosy forecasts for AI spending out in 2029 and 2030 and beyond can be met", given component supply and grid power. His counterpoint, for balance: production is sold out for 2027.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Santa Clara. The independent directors retained the former acting United States attorney Joon H. Kim and Wachtell, Lipton for "a thorough and independent investigation" on 10 November — **and did not say what is being investigated**.[5]

Austin. AMD launched its sixth-generation server processors on 10 November with **256 cores** on one socket at 600 watts, claiming up to **3.7×** an Nvidia Vera system — on its own internal estimates, which it labels as such.[6]

Hugging Face. Nvidia published a four-bit requantisation of Moonshot's Chinese frontier model on 11 November under its own licence, losing **0.13** of a point on a science benchmark.[7]

SOURCES 1 The Wyden–Neal letter to Secretary Lutnick of 12 November 2026, **read in full as a PDF on the House Ways and Means Democrats' own server**; every quotation here is verbatim from it. 2 The same letter; the Senate Finance Committee's release of 12 November. 3 SemiAnalysis, "Nvidia and the World Without Jensen", 12 November — **the free portion only; the rest is paywalled and not quoted**. The authors mark the intelligence-community inference as speculation and this desk prints that label with it. Hacker News point counts retrieved through its public search interface, 12 November. 4 The Next Platform, 12 November 18:42 Greenwich time, **read at source**. 5 Nvidia's own newsroom statement of 10 November, **read at source**. 6 AMD's investor-relations release of 10 November, 12:00 Eastern, **read at source**; AMD states the comparison figures are internal estimates. 7 The model card on Hugging Face, created 11 November, **read at source**; total file size and memory floor are **not published and are not printed here**. **Reuters, the New York Times, CNN and the Wall Street Journal all refused this desk.**

THE HOME LAB · THE CARD COSTS MORE AGAIN

Scan shows a price on one of its 27 Nvidia RTX 5090 listings

The one you can buy is £6,999.98. A week after memory cost more than the card, the cheapest RTX 5080 is £1,499.99 against £1,140.98 for the same 64GB kit.

At Scan Computers in Bolton on Friday morning, twenty-seven versions of the fastest graphics card Nvidia sells to the public were listed for sale and exactly one of them had a price next to it: a water-cooled Gigabyte at £6,999.98, in stock, delivery Saturday. One other said "call for price". The remaining twenty-five offered only a button to be notified when they exist.[1]

If you want to run one of these models on a machine you own rather than renting one over the internet, the thing you are shopping for is memory: the model is one enormous file of numbers and all of it has to sit in fast memory at once for the machine to answer quickly. That is why enthusiasts buy graphics cards — not for the graphics, but for the unusually fast memory bank bolted beside the chip. For a year the cheapest route to a lot of it was ordinary desktop memory sticks, which produced the odd result this book printed on Thursday: a pair of sticks costing more than the mid-range card they were going beside.[2]

That has reversed, and in about a week. The same factories make the memory for graphics cards and the memory for the data centres being built for artificial intelligence, and the data centres pay more. At Scan this morning the cheapest in-stock RTX 5080 is **£1,499.99** and the comparable 64GB desktop kit is **£1,140.98** — so the card sits about **£360** above the memory again, where it belongs. Fourteen of the thirty 5080 listings carry no price either. A single 64GB server memory module, the kind the data centres actually buy, is **£3,599.99**.[1]

The alternative is to buy the memory and accept a slower chip beside it. Framework's new desktop pairs **192GB** of soldered unified memory with sixteen cores at **$6,799** excluding tax; its first two November batches are both marked sold out and the third ships in December. Set that against the one 5090 you can actually buy: **$6,799 buys 192GB; £6,999.98 buys 32GB**. Every earlier Framework configuration — 32, 64 and 128GB at $1,269, $1,959 and $3,449 — is out of stock in every variant.[3]

Twenty-seven cards on the page. Twenty-six with no price.

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS ARE PAYING FOR A 5090

On Hacker News the numbers come from people holding receipts. **Sohcahtoa82** paid "$3,000 for my 5090 early last year" and reckons it now fetches about $7,000. **TrackerFF** says street prices have passed $9,000 and that "the top GPU market is now exclusively for the local LLM users"; in Norway, he reckons, a 5090 machine with 64GB now runs about $13,500 against roughly a third of that a year ago. **cpburns2009**, who owns both a 5090 and a unified-memory box, calls the prices "just insane". **Hamuko** offers the hobby's only hope: if a data-centre operator fails, its cards flood the market.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A HOME CARD CANNOT BUY AT ANY PRICE

swiftcoder, on Hacker News on 9 November: "No amount of money will buy you an RTX 5090 with 512 GB of RAM." The week's own evidence is on his side — the model Nvidia requantised to four bits on 11 November has 2.8 trillion parameters and was served on a rack-scale machine across eight devices (p7). **Foobar8568** is harsher still: local models are "a bit useless" on consumer hardware outside roleplay. **And a finding worth printing:** a 127-comment thread about a new 65-billion-parameter open-weights model produced almost no reports of anyone running it, on anything, at any speed.[5]

SOURCES 1 Scan Computers' own category and search pages for the RTX 5090, the RTX 5080 and 64GB DDR5, **read at source on 13 November 2026 Singapore time**; prices include value-added tax per the site's own header, and the count of unpriced listings is this desk's own. 2 No. 160 of this book, p8, which printed 64GB at £1,139.99 against an RTX 5080. 3 Framework's own product pages for both desktop generations, **read at source**; the page states prices exclude taxes and duties and does not name a currency code. 4 Hacker News comments of 2, 4, 6 and 10 November, retrieved through its public search interface with handles and dates as recorded. **Reddit refused this desk in every form, including two mirrors, so no r/LocalLLaMA or r/homelab thread appears here.** 5 Hacker News, 9 and 11 November, as above; the model card on Hugging Face for the parameter count and the serving configuration. **Held, not printed:** reported production cuts to the 5090 and a "2.2× list price" figure, both of which this desk could only reach as headlines; Apple's Singapore store served no price for any Mac Studio configuration; and no used-card price was read at source.

THE KIT · INTELLIGENT EYEWEAR

Samsung opened pre-orders for its display-free Intelligent Eyewear at US$395

The glasses ship on 10 December in America and South Korea only. Warby Parker's progressive lenses add US$330, which makes the real price for a reader in reading glasses US$725.

Samsung opened pre-orders on Wednesday 12 November for the camera-and-audio glasses it built with Google, at US$395 for the Warby Parker frames and US$449 to US$489 for Gentle Monster's, with general sale on 10 December. There is no screen in them. They take photographs, play audio into your ears, and answer questions.[1]

The part that matters for anyone over forty is not in the launch release. These are spectacles, and spectacles have lenses. Warby Parker's own options page prices single-vision prescription at an extra US$100, readers at US$100 and **progressives at US$330**, with light-responsive glass another US$125, thinner lenses US$60, anti-reflective US$35 and polarised US$50. A pair specified the way a mid-forties buyer would actually specify them — progressive, polarised, thinned, coated — comes to **US$1,080**. The headline price is for someone who does not need glasses.[2]

The specification is modest and sensibly so: a twelve-megapixel camera, two open-ear speakers and four microphones, nine hours of use and seven more full charges from the case, about 41 grams on the face. Thirty designs at launch, sixteen from Gentle Monster across six frames and fourteen from Warby Parker across three. The privacy engineering is better than the category's reputation — a physical switch, a white capture light that stops recording if covered or disabled, a hardware check run each time the glasses charge, recording that halts when you take them off, and bystanders' faces redacted before the model sees the frame.[1]

And none of it is for sale here. Samsung's own release names the United States and South Korea; Europe is explicitly not a launch market and Singapore is not mentioned. For a reader in Orchard Road this is a grey-import or a wait, and the honest advice is to wait: the second generation will have a display, and the first generation's lenses cost more than its frames.[1]

US$725

THE WARBY PARKER FRAME IN PROGRESSIVES

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE ANDROID PRESS NOTICED FIRST

The line the forums ran with came from **Sanuj Bhatia** at Android Police: "So yes, these Android XR glasses support iPhones before they support all Android phones." They work with recent Galaxy and Pixel handsets and with an iPhone 13 or later — and with nothing from Honor, Xiaomi or Oppo. His section heading on the price was simply "Google's first Android XR glasses aren't cheap". He also reports Warby Parker shipping to Canada as well as America, which conflicts with Samsung's own two-market release; **this desk prints the maker's version and notes the discrepancy**.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WARBY PARKER'S ADD-ON LADDER

Ben Schoon of 9to5Google went through the options list and found the base price is close to fiction. His worked examples: non-prescription with light-responsive lenses, **US$520**; progressive with polarisation, thinning and coating, **US$1,080**. He balked at the transitions pricing specifically, said he is considering Gentle Monster instead, and is put off by pre-order delays on the frame he wanted. **What the maker will not say:** the release makes a clear promise that camera visuals are not used for model training or advertising, and says nothing equivalent about voice requests.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Battery. 245 milliamp-hours in the frames, nine hours of use, and seven more full charges from a **166.8g** Warby Parker case — the case weighs four times the glasses.[3]

Translation. Google Translate runs in **more than 70** languages on the frames, with a Pixel Watch double-pinch to play and pause.[3]

SOURCES 1 Samsung Mobile Press, "Samsung Announces December Release for Intelligent Eyewear", New York, 12 November 2026, **read at source**, for every price, date, market, weight and specification, and for the privacy statements. 2 Warby Parker's lens options as 9to5Google itemised them, 12 November, 8:45 Pacific time, **read at source** — **Warby Parker's own page returned 403 to this desk**. 3 9to5Google, 12 November, 6:00 Pacific, and Android Police of the same day, both **read at source**. 4 9to5Google's add-on piece as above; the voice-request omission was first noted by PPC Land, 12 November, **also read at source**. **No Singapore price exists: Samsung's own release excludes Singapore from the launch, and Samsung's Singapore product pages returned 403. Reddit refused this desk, so no forum sentiment appears here.**

THE GOOD LIFE · OCEANUS MANTA

Casio puts a mother-of-pearl dial on the titanium Oceanus Manta at ¥236,500

The reference is OCW-S7000PW-7AJF, 42.8mm and 83 grams, on sale in Japan this month and nowhere else. An exporter is already listing it ¥22,367 below Japanese retail.

Casio has put a natural white mother-of-pearl dial into its titanium Oceanus Manta chronograph and priced it at ¥236,500 including tax, on sale in Japan this month. That is about **S$2,050**, or about **US$1,494** at the rate quoted when the watch was announced on 4 November. There is no confirmed American release and no Singapore listing.[1]

What you are buying is the unfashionable kind of good watch: a 42.8mm titanium case nine and a half millimetres thick weighing **83 grams** on its bracelet, with a pearl-white sapphire bezel ring, sapphire glass, 100 metres of water resistance, a solar cell that runs it for about five months in total darkness and nineteen in power-saving, radio time-setting from six transmitters across Japan, America, Britain, Germany and China, and twenty-seven cities of world time. It also talks to a phone. It is a quartz watch, and it will keep better time than anything mechanical at ten times the money.[2]

The Japan-only part is the whole proposition and the whole problem. Oceanus is a domestic line; buying one means buying it in Japan, where a tourist can reclaim the consumption tax, or importing it. One Japanese exporter is already listing this reference at **¥214,133** against the **¥236,500** list — a **¥22,367** discount on a watch three days old, which is not what a watch holding its price looks like.[3]

It is also not limited. No page this desk read carries a piece count, which removes the scarcity argument entirely and leaves the object to stand on what it is: the best-finished titanium quartz chronograph anyone makes, sold in one country, at a price a Grand Seiko would laugh at.[2]

¥22,367

UNDER LIST, FROM AN EXPORTER, ON DAY THREE

THE CHATTER · WHAT OCEANUS BUYERS SAY ABOUT IMPORTING ONE

This box is thinner than it should be and this desk is saying so. The community's home for this watch is a single long-running forum thread, and the host now redirects every page of it to a paywall returning "payment required". **Not one post was read at source.** What the search index surfaced, and what is therefore printed as unverified, is the shape of the import problem: members describing buying Japan-market Oceanus through proxy services, customs trouble, and one noting a rare model may still be findable "because there are no buyers from outside Japan". **Treat all of that as unread.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE AGAINST THIS OCEANUS MANTA

No English-language review of this watch exists — it is three days old — so the case against is built from what was read. There is no confirmed international release, which means no international service or warranty path on a ¥236,500 purchase. A day-one **9.5 per cent** discount from an exporter is a price signal. And the secondary market for the line is harsh: a used earlier Manta was asking **US$700** against a US$1,300 list — roughly a **46 per cent** haircut — though that figure comes from the same paywalled forum and is **unverified**. Against a Yema with a five-year international warranty at US$2,790, the ownership case is weaker than the spec sheet.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Yema. The Senans Grande Lune, an in-house micro-rotor moonphase at **US$2,790**, 38.5mm by 8.7mm, **200 pieces per dial colour**, with a five-year international warranty, ships mid-December.[6]

Omega. The Seamaster Diver 300M in brown ceramic is **US$15,500** against **US$10,000** for the all-blue ceramic — **a US$5,500 premium for the colour**.[6]

SOURCES 1 Harada, a Japanese authorised Casio dealer, for the reference and the ¥236,500 tax-inclusive price, **read at source**; Gear Patrol, 4 November 2026, for the dollar conversion and the announcement. **Casio's own Japanese, international and Singapore pages all returned 403 to this desk, so no maker page was read. One circulating report puts the Japanese on-sale date at 13 November; the dealer page says only "November 2026", so this desk prints the month.** 2 Gear Patrol as above and IPPO Japan's listing for the dimensions, weight, water resistance, power reserve, radio reception and world-time figures, **both read at source**; no piece count appears on any page read. 3 IPPO Japan's own listing for ¥214,133 against the ¥236,500 list, **read at source**. 4 **WatchUSeek's Oceanus thread now redirects to a paywall returning HTTP 402 on every page; nothing in that box was read at source and it is labelled accordingly.** 5 As above, plus Gear Patrol's line that American availability is unconfirmed; **the resale figures are search-index excerpts, not posts.** 6 yema.com's own collection page, **read at source**; the Omega prices as The Gadgeteer of 10 November reports them from the maker's site. **Yema's stated power reserve and accuracy sit under an icon named for a different movement and are not printed.**

SCREEN & SOUND · CARNAVAL DE LUZ

U2 release Carnaval de Luz, closing with Dolly Parton's last recorded vocal

The twelve-track album, the band's first in nine years, is out today on Island Records. Parton died on 25 August, aged 80; "Torn" was cut in June.

U2 released their sixteenth studio album, *Carnaval de Luz*, on Friday 13 November — twelve songs, the first since 2017 — and its closing track carries the last vocal Dolly Parton recorded before her death on 25 August, aged 80. The song is called "Torn". It was recorded in June, a couple of months before she died; Bono has described her getting out of bed to sing it.[1]

The record was produced by Jacknife Lee with additional production from Ryan Tedder, mixed by Tom Elmhirst and Steve Lillywhite among others, with Brian Eno and Leo Abrahams playing on it. Three singles preceded it — "Street of Dreams" in July, "Silencio" in September, "The Greatest Show on Earth" in October — and "Torn" arrives with the album. There are no sales or streaming figures: it is hours old, and the only aggregate number that exists is a Metacritic score of **76**.[2]

The critics divide precisely on the Parton track, which is the honest thing to report about a record nobody has lived with yet. Liz Worth at Exclaim! calls it "arguably the most significant of the album" and "the strongest diversion", full of country twang, while admitting that "at first the song feels slightly out of place". Brad Wheeler made it a critic's pick in the Globe and Mail, describing "the late country singer's fluttering vocals set against muffled beats, heavenly brass and a church organ".[3]

Three wide films open the same day — Paramount's *Ebenezer*, Amazon's *How to Rob a Bank* and Bleecker Street's *Victorian Psycho* — into a market that doubled last weekend. And a correction to this book: No. 160 gave *Godzilla Minus Zero*'s American opening as **$30,612,674**; Box Office Mojo now shows **$30,628,265**, a revision of **$15,591** upward. The second weekend does not exist yet — the chart is stamped as of Thursday 12 November and shows dashes.[4]

$4,057

PER SCREEN FOR STRAY KIDS — FOUR TIMES GODZILLA'S

THE CHATTER · WHAT REVIEWERS MAKE OF THE PARTON DUET

Exclaim! reads the album as "a triumphant return for U2" — "ambitious but accessible, catchy but substantial" — and lands on "a solid record nonetheless", which is a sentence doing some work. The Globe and Mail calls the band "humbled". Neither gives a score. **No forum or social sentiment appears on this page: Reddit refused this desk in every form, all build.** The one hard number in circulation is the Metacritic 76, and a competing 82 turned up in a search summary that the page itself does not support.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · "TORN" DOES NOT LIVE UP TO ITS BILLING

Marty Duda at 13th Floor in Auckland went straight at the thing everyone else is reverent about. Parton "sounds great", he writes, but the track is "sadly, its not her finest moment", with "zero chemistry between Dolly and the band or the song" — and the album "would be well served by losing the final two tracks". He gives no score either. **One further sceptical verdict in the same direction, from Ultimate Classic Rock, reached this desk only as a search summary and is not quoted.**[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Box office. *Godzilla Minus Zero* opened to **$30,628,265** in 3,254 cinemas for GKIDS and pulled the whole top ten up **104.9 per cent** to **$104,446,626**.[4]

Concert film. Stray Kids' *Run It* tour film took **$3,720,294** from **917** screens — a per-screen average more than four times Godzilla's.[4]

Also out today. Jake Bugg's *Alamo*, Becky Hill's *REBECCA* on Polydor, and super-deluxe reissues of Talking Heads' *Fear of Music* and The Flaming Lips' *At War With the Mystics*.[6]

SOURCES 1 u2.com's own front page, **read at source**, for the 13 November release and "twelve new songs… the first studio album in nine years"; Parton's death on 25 August 2026 at 80, the June recording and Bono's account are carried by Associated Press copy syndicated across a dozen American stations on 27 September 2026, which this desk checked against three separate outlets before printing. 2 The album's own public record for the personnel, tracklist and single dates, and for the Metacritic figure. **The label is given as Island in two places and Interscope in a third; this desk prints Island and notes the conflict.** 3 Exclaim!, 11 November, and the Globe and Mail, 10 November, both **read at source**. 4 Box Office Mojo's own weekend page for 6–8 November and its release calendar for 13 November, both **read at source on 13 November**; the 46th-week page shows dashes and the index is stamped "as of Thu, Nov 12", which is why there is no second-weekend figure here. 5 13th Floor, Auckland, 12 November, **read at source**. 6 Pause&Play's New Music Friday listing for 13 November, **read at source**. **Billboard and Bloomberg are paywalled and were not circumvented.**

THE MACRO DESK · A HUNDRED PER CENT

Futures price the Fed at 100 per cent for a December rise

The argument has moved from whether the Federal Reserve raises on 9 December to by how much: 88.3 per cent for a quarter point, 11.7 for a half, nothing at all for a hold. Gold fell 2.80 per cent the same day.

At Thursday's close the futures market put no probability at all on the Federal Reserve leaving rates alone on 9 December. A quarter-point rise carried 88.3 per cent and a half point 11.7, against 7.6 a day earlier; a week before, a hold had been the base case at 33.7. In five sessions the market stopped arguing about direction and began arguing about size.[1]

The cause is a print and a speech on one Tuesday. October core inflation came in at **0.3 per cent** for the month — identical to September and August — with the headline at **0.4** against about 0.3 expected. Hours earlier in London, the Federal Reserve governor Christopher Waller said he was "leaning toward supporting" a quarter-point rise in December, and that **a half point should be considered if core came in around 0.3 or higher**. It came in at exactly 0.3: he set his own trigger and the data pulled it.[2]

One oddity changes how the decision is made: there is no twelve-month inflation rate at all. The statistics bureau says plainly that it collected no survey data for October 2025 because of the lapse in appropriations. The Fed is tightening off monthly momentum alone — three-month core near **3.7 per cent** annualised — and the annual series returns with the November print on 10 December, the day after the decision.[2]

The chain ran through the instruments cleanly. Two-year yields rose **14.2 basis points** and ten-year **12.3** — a bear flattening led by the front end, which is a policy-expectations move, not a supply one. The dollar index added **0.24 per cent** to **103.17**, and the Singapore dollar gave up **0.25** despite a band still set to appreciate. Then the long-duration assets took it: **gold −2.80 per cent**, **bitcoin −3.9**, against an all-world equity fund down **0.06**. Gold falling more than forty times as hard as global equities on a hawkish day is a real-rate regime, not a growth scare.[3]

0%

THE MARKET'S PROBABILITY OF A DECEMBER HOLD

THE LEVELS · AT THURSDAY 12 NOVEMBER'S CLOSE

US 10-year[3]	5.129%	▲ 12.3bp
VWRA[4]	$189.50	▼ 0.06%
AGGU[4]	$5.80	▼ 0.14%
Gold[4]	$3,876.14	▼ 2.80%
USD/SGD[4]	1.2873	▲ 0.25%
Straits Times[4]	5,282.70	▼ 0.13%

Brent is held: three sources gave $96.12, $104.62 and about $91.70 for the same session.[5]

THE VERDICT · WHAT A HUNDRED PER CENT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

The regime is tightening, dollar-bid and higher-for-longer. There is no dove on the tape: Lorie Logan wants "at least two more 25-basis-point rate increases", Beth Hammack a "restrictive stance" in "smaller, more frequent" steps. The dissent is about speed, not direction. For a global equity-and-bond portfolio, both legs fell together, the bond leg by more. **Not advice.**[6]

THE SCEPTIC · BOOCKVAR SAID THE FED WOULD NOT HIKE

Peter Boockvar of One Point BFG argued on 30 October that "if tech stocks continue to falter here, the Fed will not be hiking rates in December" — and that a hold would weaken the dollar and give gold its chance. The faltering arrived: Nvidia fell 14 per cent intraday, its founder gone (p3). The market moved to full pricing anyway.[7]

SOURCES 1 Investing.com's Fed Rate Monitor, built on CME Group thirty-day federal-funds futures, last updated 12 November 3:45pm Eastern, **read at source. CME's own FedWatch tool returned HTTP 503 to this desk, so the split is attributed to the derived monitor and not to FedWatch itself.** 2 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own October release, **read at source**, including its statement that no survey data were collected for October 2025 and that no twelve-month rates are published; Waller's London remarks of 10 November as reported in the same compilation. 3 Investing.com's own bond-yield pages, **read at source**, cross-checked against CNBC's 12 November levels to within a basis point. **No real-yield source was opened, so the real-rate reading here is inferred from the nominal move and is labelled as inference.** 4 Each instrument read at its own quote page on 12 November; **none of those pages prints a calendar date, so the session was anchored by cross-check against the Straits Times index history and an on-page economic calendar.** Bitcoin is printed as approximate because the quote page does not reconcile its own last price with its own change. 5 The three Brent sources are named in this desk's working note and none is printed. 6 Logan, Hammack and Daly as reported on 10 and 12 November, **each read at source**. 7 gurufocus, 30 October, for Boockvar and Saravelos, **read at source**. **Market explanation and education, not investment advice; forecasts are flagged as forecasts.**

THE FAMILY DESK · FIFTEEN YEARS OF TEN-TO-FIFTEENS

Emotional problems among British 10- to 15-year-olds rose from 11.4 to 27.1 per cent

The European Journal of Epidemiology published the fifteen-year trend on 11 November, from 16,356 children. Over the same years conduct problems fell, from 13.6 per cent to 11.4.

A study published in the European Journal of Epidemiology on 11 November followed more than sixteen thousand British children aged ten to fifteen across fifteen years, and found the share showing real emotional difficulty went from about one in nine to more than one in four. Among girls the 2024 figure is **38.9 per cent**; among boys, **15.8**.[1]

It matters because of what else the same children were doing. Over those fifteen years, in the same household survey, they were drinking less, smoking less, staying out late less and fighting with their parents less — and conduct problems fell outright, from 13.6 per cent to 11.4. A generation in free fall does not simultaneously stop drinking and stop arguing with its mother. Hyperactivity, flat until 2017, then rose to **27.4 per cent**.[1]

A second finding cuts against the obvious culprit at precisely twelve. A meta-analysis in *Clinical Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, online 6 November, pooled twelve studies on social-media use and adolescent mental health and found the association differs significantly by school stage: strongest in primary school at **r = 0.367**, then high school at **0.334**, and **weakest in the middle years at 0.201**. If the link is real, it is less strong at twelve than at ten.[2]

And the policy argument is being made from this city. A comment in *The Lancet Child & Adolescent Health* on 10 November, led from Singapore Management University with co-authors at Oxford, Harvard Medical School and the University of California, argues for "digital readiness, not age". Its body text is paywalled and unread here, so the position is reported, not quoted. Three weeks later Singapore's government reached the same conclusion from its own fieldwork (p14).[3]

0.201

THE MIDDLE-SCHOOL ASSOCIATION — THE WEAKEST OF THREE

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE BRITISH EMOTIONAL-PROBLEMS TREND LEAVES OUT

Singapore's education ministry has published the caution this kind of number needs. On its termly well-being check-ins it told Parliament in September that the proportion of students flagged "should not be interpreted as overall well-being levels or prevalence of mental-health concerns", and is "not a measure of whether student well-being has improved or worsened over time". For trends it points to the Youth Epidemiology and Resilience study instead.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · DO NOT READ 27.1 PER CENT ONTO YOUR OWN CHILD

The strongest anti-alarmist argument is inside the paper itself, and it is the reason to print it. Self-reported emotional difficulty more than doubled while four separate behavioural risks fell in the same children, in the same years, measured the same way. That pattern is at least as consistent with children becoming more willing and able to name distress as with more distress existing. **What this desk could not read:** the paper's full strengths-and-limitations section — the publisher's site redirected to a login wall and no open copy exists yet — so no limitation is quoted here. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Advertising. A screen-capture study of 1,011 young people aged 8 to 17 puts median food and drink advert exposure at **3,883 a year** — and **10,107** for the over-tens. **82.6 per cent** arrived on social media and **91.6 per cent** of the non-restaurant items failed regional nutrient standards.[6]

Screens and siblings. In 8,706 Australian children followed from six to thirteen, becoming a single-parent household changed screen time by **18 minutes a week**, indistinguishable from zero. Each additional sibling cut it by **22.7 minutes**.[6]

SOURCES 1 Taxiarchi and colleagues, "Trends in mental health and behavioural outcomes in UK 10–15 year olds from 2009 to 2024", *European Journal of Epidemiology*, online 11 November 2026, from the United Kingdom Household Longitudinal Study: 16,356 participants and 46,218 observations. **Abstract and every figure read at source on the national library's own record.** 2 Han, Meng and Yang, *Clinical Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, online 6 November 2026: twelve studies, fifteen effect sizes, pooled r = 0.308, heterogeneity high at 93.85 per cent, stage difference significant at p = 0.008. **Read at source.** 3 Zhang and colleagues, "Digital readiness, not age", *The Lancet Child & Adolescent Health*, online 10 November 2026 — **title, authorship and affiliations confirmed at source; the article itself is closed access and was not read, so nothing in it is quoted.** 4 Singapore's Ministry of Education, parliamentary reply of 8 September 2026, **read at source**. 5 The paper as above; **the publisher's own page redirected to an identity-provider wall and the open repository returned 403, so the limitations section is unread and flagged.** 6 Powell and colleagues, *JAMA Pediatrics*, online 9 November 2026; Shifera, Pagano and Sanders, *European Journal of Pediatrics*, online 9 November 2026 — **both read at source**, with the second's confidence interval spanning zero as printed.

THE TWEEN YEARS · TIERED, NOT BANNED

Eight in ten Singapore parents back tiered social-media access rather than a ban

Singapore's digital ministry built its 23 October factsheet on more than 2,000 parents and young people; youth support for a tiered approach runs near 70 per cent. Secondary One postings land on 18 December.

Singapore's Ministry of Digital Development and Information asked more than two thousand parents and young people what to do about social media, and both groups told it the same thing: do not ban it, open it in stages, and build the safety settings in by default. More than 80 per cent of parents backed a tiered approach; nearly 70 per cent of young people did.[1]

It matters because Australia took the opposite route, a hard cut-off at sixteen. Singapore has effectively decided that a twelve-year-old should learn to handle these applications with guardrails rather than meet them first at sixteen — the same argument a Singapore-led paper made in a London medical journal three weeks earlier (p13). The defaults parents supported: **disable autoplay, 76 per cent**; **disable direct messaging, 75**; **a daily time limit, 75**. Young people put full access at sixteen; parents at eighteen.[1]

Honesty about the instrument: this was an engagement exercise, not a representative national survey. It ran from June to August 2026 through focus groups, school dialogues and a crowdsourced poll — and publishes no sample size for the survey arm, no parent-to-youth split and no age bands. One parent quoted in it: "Allowing controlled access helps children gradually learn to navigate social media responsibly." The ministry's own summary is the headline: neither parents nor young people favoured an outright ban.[1]

For a household whose child sat this year's leaving examination, the dates are the thing. Results come on **24 or 25 November**, provisionally, at 11am; six school choices open at 11.30 that morning and close at 4.30pm on the last day of a seven-day window; and **Secondary One posting results arrive on Friday 18 December**. Term one of 2027 begins for Secondary One on **Monday 4 January**. She walks into a phone regime that tightened in January: devices in lockers or bags for **all school hours**, recess and activities included, and the school laptop's default sleep brought forward from **11pm to 10.30pm**.[2]

10.30pm

WHEN THE SCHOOL LAPTOP NOW SLEEPS, DOWN FROM ELEVEN

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE MINISTRY WILL NOT SAY ABOUT PRESSURE

Asked directly on 3 November whether it had evaluated what tightening affiliation requirements has done to academic pressure and tuition reliance, the education ministry produced no findings — the drivers are "complex and multi-faceted", it said, pointing to its Education Conversations and a 2026 policy-institute survey. It confirmed that since 2019 at least **20 per cent** of places in each posting group must be held for non-affiliated pupils, and it declines to cap the gap between affiliated and non-affiliated cut-offs. On 4 November, answering Pritam Singh, it conceded that "excessive competition persists" and that it has received suggestions including adjusting the scoring bands, which it "will study… carefully".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TIERED ACCESS IS A PREFERENCE, NOT EVIDENCE

What the factsheet establishes is what Singaporeans want, not what works. No outcome is measured in it; no comparison with Australia's ban is attempted; and the one table of concern percentages is scrambled in the page's own markup, so this desk cannot match its figures to parents or to children and does not print them. The strongest number in the whole exercise is a different ministry's: **one in three** of those aged 10 to 18 report symptoms of depression or anxiety and **70 per cent** of those did not seek professional help. Consultation on their access to care closes at 6pm on 8 December. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[4]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Digital Development and Information's own factsheet, "Singapore Teens and Parents Agree: Safer Social Media, Not No Social Media", published 23 October 2026 and last updated 11 November, **read at source** — including its own statement of method, its four named community partners and the quoted parent. **Its concern-percentage table does not resolve reliably in the page markup and those figures are deliberately omitted here.** 2 Singapore's Ministry of Education: its Secondary One posting page for the dates and the choice window, its school-terms release of 14 July 2026 for the 2027 calendar, and its release of 30 November 2025 for the phone rules and the laptop sleep hour — **all read at source**. 3 The ministry's parliamentary replies of 3 and 4 November 2026 and 9 September 2026, **read at source**. 4 The factsheet as above; the Ministry of Health's own consultation notice of 11 November 2026 for the prevalence figures and the closing time, **read at source**. **Held:** the policy institute's own working paper, which the education ministry cites twice, could not be opened — its publication page serves a stub and three direct paths returned 404 — so none of its circulating figures is printed.

THE INVITATION · SOFTWARE-DEFINED RADIO

A television tuner, the RTL2832U, gave amateurs a cheap spectrum analyser

The entry dongle costs US$37.95 and receives from about 500 kilohertz to 1.75 gigahertz. The hobby's own catalogue lists 594 identified signals — and 408 nobody has named.

Software-defined radio is what happens when you plug a cheap stick into a computer and the computer becomes a radio that can look at several megahertz of spectrum at once. You do not transmit. You listen — and then, because listening alone palls, you identify. The sport is turning an unexplained smear on a scrolling display into a named protocol, and then into decoded text: an aircraft's tail number, a ship's draught, a pager message, a weather balloon's altitude.[1]

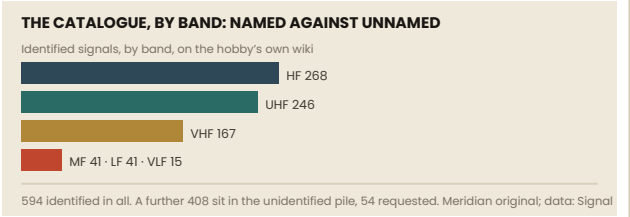
It began as an accident of mass manufacture. Antti Palosaari, Eric Fry and the Osmocom project found that cheap television-tuner sticks, built to decode digital broadcast television, could be persuaded to hand over their raw samples instead of a picture. A twenty-dollar accessory became an instrument. The maker whose blog is now the hobby's newspaper of record puts the result plainly: it "democratized access to the radio spectrum".[1]

The hook is well documented and always the same shape: you buy the thing for one reason and the spectrum sells you another. The best-written account is blinry's *Fifty Things you can do with a Software Defined Radio*, of March 2024 — "It's like an invisible world that always surrounds us", and, on a first weather satellite, "I was super excited", and, on shortwave after dark, "Wow. It's full of stars!" A blogger who bought a dongle to read a wireless thermometer discovered aircraft broadcasts sat in the same band and was, in their word, "hooked".[2]

The scale is modest in people and enormous in instrumentation. The largest forum has about **140,000** members and the signal-identification annex **36,000**; but the aircraft-tracking exchange claims **more than 25,000 receivers**, and the shipping-data network lists **1,797** stations. The honest measure of the field is its own catalogue: **594** signals identified, **408** still unidentified and waiting. The next two pages are about the kit, which is in worse shape than it was a year ago, and the software, which has just done something genuinely new.[3]

408

CATALOGUED SIGNALS NOBODY HAS IDENTIFIED



The field's own measure of itself: two-fifths of what it has catalogued, it cannot name.

THE CHATTER · WHERE SOFTWARE-DEFINED RADIO BEGINNERS GO WRONG

On Hacker News in May 2025, **jcims** named the hook with precision — what gets a person in is "software that works and interesting use cases you can get into with cheap hardware" — and warned that handing a beginner the serious signal-processing toolkit first "might equate with a brick wall". **0xEF** was blunter about the market: "There's a lot of garbage equipment out there", including dongles that emit spurious signals of their own. **darthcloud** pointed instead at pysdr.org, which is free.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE THIRTY-DOLLAR DONGLE CANNOT DO WEATHER SATELLITES

Every beginner's guide still online tells you to receive a weather-satellite picture on a thirty-dollar dongle. You cannot. The American polar satellites that made that the hobby's gateway are off: NOAA-18's transmitter failed and was shut down on 6 June 2025, and NOAA-15 and NOAA-19 were decommissioned that August. The replacements — Meteor-M, Metop and the geostationary services — all need a dish. **A guide that still promises those pictures was written in 2019 and nobody has told it.**[5]

SOURCES 1 rtl-sdr.com's own "About" page, **read at source**, for the frequency range, the receive-only limitation, the origin credit and the "democratized" quotation. 2 blinry, *Fifty Things you can do with a Software Defined Radio*, 16 March 2024, CC BY-SA 4.0, **read at source**; the thermometer-to-aircraft account is a personal blog of 8 July 2017, **also read at source**. 3 The Signal Identification Wiki's own guide page for all band counts; ADS-B Exchange's own media kit for the receiver claim (**its "key stats" tiles render as empty placeholders, so that one sentence is the only usable figure on the page**); AISHub's own station list for 1,797. **Forum membership figures are third-party scrapes of public counts: Reddit refuses this desk outright in every form, so no count here is read at Reddit itself and none should be treated as exact.** 4 Hacker News, 30 May 2025, handles as recorded, **read at source**. 5 The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's shutdowns as rtl-sdr.com reported and dated them, 15 and 22 August 2025.

THE DEEP END · THE DONGLE, THE FILTER, THE MAST

Rafael Micro stopped the R828D, and RTL-SDR Blog retired its best dongle

The V4 went end-of-line on 14 May 2026 after counterfeit tuner chips turned up in third-party stock. Its replacement, the V4L, is itself a limited run on about a year of silicon.

The cheap end of radio reception rests on scavenged television silicon, and in May the silicon ran out. Rafael Micro stopped making the R828D tuner at the heart of the hobby's standard dongle; the stockpile was exhausted and the chips still on offer from third parties turned out to be fakes. The product every beginner's guide online tells you to buy no longer exists.[1]

What replaced it is a competent holding action rather than progress. The V4L, launched on 11 August 2026 at **US$37.95**, uses the R828S, which has one fewer radio input — so two-way front-end filtering instead of three-way, and no broadcast notch at all, because the chip lacks the pin for it. The maker's framing is honest: less filtering, but "slightly better sensitivity because of lower front-end losses". A V5 is "in the very early stages of scoping", nothing expected before 2027.[1]

Above that the ladder is short. The precision instrument for the shortwave bands is the **Airspy HF+ Discovery at US$169**; the general-purpose workhorse is the **Airspy R2, also US$169**; SDRplay's **RSP1B is £105.80** before tax, its dual-tuner **RSPduo £214**, its networked **nRSP-ST £382**. The transmit-capable tier the security crowd buys — the **HackRF Pro, US$400**, shipping since January 2026 — is the wrong purchase for a listener. The measurement tier runs from **US$4,950** to **US$54,995** and hears nothing a US$169 Airspy cannot.[2]

None of which decides your results. The chain in front of the receiver matters more: a **US$16.95** notch filter fixes the commonest complaint in the hobby, a **US$19.95** amplifier at the antenna beats a better box indoors, and the **US$39.95** YouLoop is the cheapest meaningful upgrade an apartment-dweller can make. One maker's best range figure, about 400 kilometres on aircraft signals, came from moving the same receiver from "a challenging urban window location" to "a hill with nearly 360° horizon view".[3]

US$134

DONGLE, NOTCH FILTER, AMPLIFIER, PIGTAILS AND LOOP

WHAT IT COSTS TO BE SERIOUS — FIVE TIERS

Curious — V4L and the bundled dipole, **US$47.95**. **Equipped** — add the notch filter, the amplifier, a pigtail set and a YouLoop: **about US$134**, roughly S$174. **Serious** — an HF+ Discovery, an R2 and an RSP1B with filters: **about US$578**. **Committed** — add an RSPduo or the nRSP-ST, a W6LVP loop at US$445 and a disciplined clock: **US$1,700–2,100**. **Obsessive** — a HackRF Pro, a US$750 KrakenSDR, a dish and a six-receiver rig: **US$2,500–4,000**.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENTS IN THE RTL-SDR BLOG THREADS

Four, all live. **The clones:** the maker's own "genuine" page says most marketplace sellers ship "inferior fakes missing features like HF mode, bias tee, and TCXO", and gives tells — "the biggest giveaway is the two screws being horizontal, instead of on a diagonal". **The bias tee:** "Only use it while connected to an actual powered device", or you cook the regulator. **The drivers:** told that compiling from source was no big deal, **AsciiWolf** replied — "Sorry, but it is a big deal for most regular users".[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE AIRSPY IS THE LEAST IMPORTANT PURCHASE

The hobby's own reviewers keep telling readers not to upgrade, and they are right. On the HydraSDR RFOne — a US$189 rebuild of the Airspy R2 by one of its designers — the verdict was better shielding, cleaner spurs, a sensitivity difference that "may be chip variance", and "not a worthwhile upgrade for existing R2 owners". On the HackRF Pro, **RHCP**: "Not nearly enough to warrant upgrading from an old HackRF One." A four-way shootout found a **US$40** loop beating a US$445 one on signal-to-noise in some bands. **Height and a filter beat a better box.**[6]

SOURCES 1 rtl-sdr.com's own end-of-line notice of 14 May 2026, its V4L launch post of 11 August 2026 and the V4L users guide, all **read at source**, for the tuner change, the filtering, the missing notch, the quoted sensitivity line and the V5 position. 2 v3.airspy.us, sdrplay.com's own product pages, sparkfun.com and signalhound.com, all **read at source on 12 November 2026**; SDRplay prices exclude value-added tax as its own pages state, and the RSPdx-R2 is out of stock, which is why it is not priced here. 3 rtl-sdr.com's own store for the filter, amplifier and loop prices; Great Scott Gadgets' own published measurements of 3 December 2025 for the range figures and the two locations. 4 Prices as above; the Singapore-dollar conversion is this desk's own arithmetic at about 1.30 and is approximate. 5 rtl-sdr.com's "genuine" page and its V4L comment threads, **read at source**, handles as recorded. 6 rtl-sdr.com's HydraSDR review of 2 July 2025 and its loop comparison, **read at source**. **Held:** KiwiSDR's site returned 503 on every attempt, so no price for it appears; LimeSDR publishes none; RFNM sells through a campaign page and publishes none; Wellbrook's domain now redirects to an unrelated site, so it is described that way rather than declared closed.

THE DEEP END · THE DECODERS MOVE INTO THE BROWSER

SDRangel 8.0 opens the radio to a language model, and Whisper transcribes the voice

SDRangel's 25 October release bumped a whole version number on one feature: a server that lets a model drive the receiver. A fix for its version negotiation followed within days.

The most interesting thing to happen to amateur radio reception this year is not a receiver, and this page is about the software instead. On 25 October 2026 SDRangel released version 8.0 and justified the whole-number jump on one feature: a server exposing the radio — its tuning, its demodulators, its scanning — to a large language model as a set of tools. It is model-agnostic: you point your own model at your own aerial and ask it questions.[1]

That is genuinely new and its impact entirely unproven, and the evidence for both halves sits in one place: the release notes say users may need to hand the model the project's own band guide to get sensible answers, and a follow-up fix corrected the protocol version negotiation within days. Version 8.1 arrived on 9 November with an aircraft-messaging decoder.[1]

The pattern around it is the year's real story: decoding is moving off the desktop into the browser, and machine transcription is becoming a normal part of the chain — a browser scanner with automatic Whisper transcription on 29 October, a browser receiver adding digital-broadcast decoding on 5 November, unattended overnight shortwave scanning on 2 November.[2]

From Singapore the geography is the luxury and the regulation the catch. This is arguably the best place on earth to listen to shipping — the port recorded **3.22 billion** gross tons of vessel arrivals and **44.66 million** containers in 2025, and the global ship-data network lists no station here on the first page of its directory — and Changi makes aircraft decoding work indoors on day one. But Singapore Customs' page for the media regulator lists "scanning receivers" among equipment needing approval before entry, and nobody has published whether a receive-only dongle counts.[3]

1,797

SHIP-DATA STATIONS WORLDWIDE; NONE LISTED HERE

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS — AN HONEST PATH

Fortnight one: spend nothing. Read the trade blog's feed daily, and answer other people's screenshots in the signal-identification forum. Listen through somebody else's aerial first; the local society runs two web receivers here. **Then buy once:** dongle, notch filter, amplifier, pigtails and loop, **US$134**, from the official store, never a marketplace — and install the maker's driver fork first, or the dongle receives nothing. **Then buy nothing more:** aircraft and shipping want height and coax; shortwave the US$169 Discovery.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TOOLCHAIN IS ONE PERSON'S FREE TIME

The software this hobby runs on is thinner than its reputation. GNU Radio: no release since February 2025. SDR#: revision 1921, dated the first of January 2025. SDR++: the stable build is from 2023 and everyone runs a nightly whose own page warns its source archive is out of step. **The entry hardware is one discontinued chip; the software is four or five people's spare evenings.**[5]

NEXT DESCENTS · PICK TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Amateur seismology & infrasound — garage-floor sensors catching distant quakes, quarry blasts and bolides, feeding global citizen-science networks.

Species orchid growing — vanda and bulbophyllum obsessives, mounted roots, flowering cycles in years, and a judging registry. Singapore is a world capital of it.

Mechanical music restoration — player pianos, orchestrions and fairground organs: pneumatics rebuilt in leather, rolls scanned and re-cut.

SOURCES 1 SDRangel's own release notes for version 8.0.0 of 25 October 2026, the subsequent version-negotiation fix, and version 8.1.0 of 9 November 2026 — all **read at source** from the project's public release feed, since this desk's access to the hosting platform's interface was refused. 2 Each dated release as rtl-sdr.com covered it, **read at source**; GNU Radio's own release history for the February 2025 date. 3 Singapore's Maritime and Port Authority figures for 2025 as PortNews reported them on 2 July 2026; AISHub's own station directory; Singapore Customs' own page on the media regulator's import requirements, **read at source**, which lists "scanning receivers and transmitters that are used for unlawful transmissions, interception and jamming of signals". **That clause is genuinely ambiguous and this desk is not resolving it: the Dealers Regulations returned 403 and every page from the regulator's own site rendered empty. The question worth putting on the record is whether a receive-only dongle is a "scanning receiver" for import.** 4 The reading list and prices as on p16; the Singapore Amateur Radio Transmitting Society's own site for its two web receivers — **its membership fee is not published**. 5 Each project's own release page, **read at source**. **The aircraft-tracking exchange's acquisition row, in which feeders unplugged and the count fell from 9,234, is held over for want of room.**

FITNESS · THE PERTH LIFTING TRIAL

Lifting kept 1.09kg more lean tissue on tirzepatide, a Perth trial finds

The 120-person T-REx trial appeared in Nature Medicine on 9 November. Both arms lost about 22kg; the other main outcome, fat mass, came back null at P=0.416.

A trial in Perth put a hundred and twenty people on a powerful weight-loss injection for forty weeks and sent half of them to a supervised gym session three times a week. Both groups lost the same twenty-two kilograms. The weights made no difference at all to how much fat came off — but the lifters held on to more muscle, and left measurably stronger, while the drug-only group walked away about a tenth weaker than when they started.[1]

That matters beyond anyone taking the drug, because losing weight fast by any means takes muscle with it, and muscle is what a mid-forties body cannot easily buy back. The trial is the cleanest test yet: forty weeks, supervised hour-long sessions, **91 per cent** adherence, no diet intervention.[1]

Now the part the press release did not lead with. The trial had **two** co-primary outcomes and split its significance threshold between them, hence the 97.5 per cent intervals. Fat mass: −17.19kg against −17.98kg, a difference of **0.77kg**, not significant, **P = 0.416**. Lean soft tissue: −4.67kg against −3.57kg, a difference of **1.09kg**, **P below 0.001**. One of its two main questions came back null — and it was powered to detect 1.0kg, so the 1.09 only just clears the bar it set, with the interval reaching down to 0.43.[1]

Strength is where the effect is unambiguous: bench press moved **−4.09kg against +4.68kg**, lat pulldown **−4.42 against +8.58**, knee extension **−4.42 against +5.88**. Blood pressure, glucose, insulin and cholesterol improved identically in both arms — the lifting added nothing there. Participants were 50 to 70, mean **57.7**, sedentary and overweight, without diabetes or heart disease. **That band does not contain a trained mid-forties reader; general guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

P = 0.416

THE FAT-MASS OUTCOME THE HEADLINES SKIPPED

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TIRZEPATIDE TRIAL'S NUMBERS BECAME

This box is thin and the reason is the date. Four days after publication there is no reaction from the longevity-discourse names — nothing from Attia, Hutchinson, Vigotsky or Nuckols, no expert-reaction release, and Reddit refused this desk. The one practitioner write-up is an unsigned trade piece of 11 November. What it usefully flags is drift: the "up to 25 per cent" and "10 per cent strength" figures in coverage are re-expressions, not the paper's own numbers.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TRIAL'S LEAN SOFT TISSUE IS NOT MUSCLE

The sharpest objection to this trial is in the trial, and the authors make it themselves. What was measured is lean soft tissue by bone-density scan, a category broader than muscle; the authors' own estimate of real muscle lost is about **2.5kg** on the drug alone against **2kg** with training — roughly **half a kilogram** after forty weeks of supervised training. Add the design: open-label, testers unblinded, no placebo arm, a narrow and healthy population. Professor Danny Green's own line on longevity is "*in theory*, that should translate to a longer healthspan" — **no healthspan outcome was measured.**[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Your ring undercounts. Against a sleep-laboratory headband across **210** paired nights, an Oura ring underestimated total sleep by **14.6 minutes** and dream sleep by **23.8**, and overstated how long you took to fall asleep by **11.4**. The practical hook: readings below **85 per cent** efficiency were the least reliable — a bad-looking night is also the least trustworthy one. Mean age 74, so **not a mid-forties wrist**; the laboratory is Michael Chee's at the National University of Singapore.[5]

SOURCES 1 Green and colleagues, "Resistance exercise to attenuate lean mass loss during tirzepatide therapy for obesity: a randomized controlled trial", *Nature Medicine*, online 9 November 2026, registered on the Australian and New Zealand trial registry in November 2023 — **the full article read at source**, including both co-primary outcomes, the 97.5 per cent intervals, the power calculation and the adherence figure. 2 The same paper for every strength figure, the cardiometabolic nulls and the eligibility band; Eli Lilly supplied the drug and the paper states it had no other role. 3 An unsigned trade write-up of 11 November, **read at source and labelled as trade rather than expert**; the Yahoo rounding checked independently. **Nothing from Peter Attia, Alex Hutchinson, Andrew Vigotsky, Greg Nuckols or any expert-reaction service exists four days after publication, and Reddit refused this desk in every form — which is why this page carries no community read and says so.** 4 The paper's own discussion for the muscle estimate, the "did not completely prevent" concession and every limitation; the University of Western Australia's release of 10 November for Professor Green's quoted remarks, **read at source**. 5 Golkashani and colleagues, *Sleep Health*, online 4 November 2026, **read at source** — 45 adults, mean age 74.4, 210 paired nights. **General guidance, not medical advice. Nothing here supports starting a prescription drug, and the trial does not apply to a lean, trained reader in their forties.**

THE DIARY · CHRISTMAS WONDERLAND PRICES

Gardens by the Bay finally prices Christmas Wonderland, from S$9 an adult

Seven issues of asking ends in a three-band table: S$9 off-peak against S$16 same-day at super peak, and S$7 flat for a child. Sumo tickets open on 5 December.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

27 Nov–3 Jan — ★ **Christmas Wonderland 2026 · the price is out**
SUPERTREE GROVE · ADULT **S$9 ADVANCE / S$12 SAME-DAY OFF-PEAK** (27 NOV–3 DEC, 7–10 DEC), **S$11/S$14 PEAK, S$13/S$16 SUPER PEAK** (4–6, 11–13, 18–27 DEC) · **CHILD 3–12 A FLAT S$7** · ADVANCE SALES CLOSE THE NIGHT BEFORE[1]

11 Dec–4 Apr — ★ **Pop after Pop: Art around Us · 30% off to 30 Nov**
NATIONAL GALLERY, WITH THE GUGGENHEIM · **FROM S$15**, FREE FOR LOCALLY BASED STUDENTS AND UNDER-7S · **30 PER CENT OFF AUTOMATICALLY UNTIL 30 NOVEMBER**, TICKETS VALID 180 DAYS — BUY NOW, GO IN JANUARY[2]

20 Nov–3 Jan — **Christmas Train Show · Flower Dome**
GARDENS BY THE BAY · NO SEPARATE TICKET — **FLOWER DOME ADMISSION APPLIES AND THE PAGE STILL GIVES NO FIGURE** · OPENS A WEEK BEFORE WONDERLAND, INDOORS AND COLD[1]

20–29 Nov — **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · TICKETED SHOWS **S$25–S$57.20** · **THE OPENING PERFORMANCE AND SEVERAL OTHERS ARE FREE** · IT OPENS IN SEVEN DAYS[3]

21–24 Jan — **ART SG 2027 · two-for-one ends 24 Nov**
MARINA BAY SANDS · FRIDAY PAIR **S$40** AGAINST S$80, SATURDAY AND SUNDAY **S$44** AGAINST S$88, VERNISSAGE PAIR **S$94** AGAINST S$188 · **OFFER ENDS 11.59PM ON 24 NOVEMBER** · 16 AND UNDER FREE WITH A TICKETED ADULT[4]

23 JAN — **BOYNEXTDOOR · Knock On Vol.2**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 5PM · **S$188–S$328** · GENERAL SALE OPENED 4 SEPTEMBER, SO THIS IS REMAINING STOCK — **SEATED, NOT STANDING, FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD**[5]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan — ★ **Hatsu Basho · tickets open 5 December**
RYOGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALES START SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER**, NO TIME OF DAY GIVEN · **THE TOURNAMENT RUNNING NOW IN FUKUOKA IS SOLD OUT ON EVERY DATE, WITH NO DAY-OF SALES** — THE WHOLE ARGUMENT FOR AN ALARM[6]

13 Nov–14 Feb — ★ **Le Petit Prince · opens today**
TOKYO CITY VIEW, ROPPONGI HILLS · ADULT **¥2,400 ON-SITE / ¥2,200 ONLINE**, CHILD 4 TO JUNIOR-HIGH **¥1,100 / ¥1,000** · **THE COMBINATION TICKET WITH THE MORI SHOW IS ¥4,500 ADULT AND ¥1,000 A CHILD, FLAT AT WEEKENDS** · ADVANCE BOOKING REQUIRED[7]

31 Oct–28 Mar — **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI · **¥2,800 ON-SITE, ¥2,600 ONLINE ON A WEEKDAY; JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · HER FIRST MAJOR RETROSPECTIVE IN JAPAN SINCE 2002, ABOUT FORTY WORKS, WITH THE GUGGENHEIM[7]

30 Oct–11 Jan — **Haikyu!! Challengers · Haruichi Furudate**
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS · **NO PRICE ON THE MUSEUM'S OWN EXHIBITIONS PAGE** · AIMED SQUARELY AT A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD, AND IN THE SAME BUILDING AS THE TWO ABOVE[7]

PLANNING NOTES · THE TWO DEADLINES AND THE ALARM

Two deadlines inside a fortnight. The National Gallery's **30 per cent** comes off automatically until **30 November** and the tickets stay valid 180 days — a discount you can bank and spend later. **ART SG's two-for-one ends at 11.59pm on 24 November. The alarm is 5 December**, when January's sumo opens; the proof it matters is that this week's tournament is sold out on all fifteen days. **Best value for a twelve-year-old:** free at ART SG with a ticketed adult, free at the Mori museum, ¥1,000 on the Roppongi combination ticket, S$7 flat at Wonderland. **Go off-peak:** a Wonderland evening before 3 December costs S$9 against S$16 same-day in the 18–27 December crush. **Dropped deliberately:** the Sapporo Snow Festival, whose English site still carries only 2025; the ArtScience Museum, because Marina Bay Sands returned a server error on all five pages tried; Singapore Art Week, Huayi and teamLab, none with a primary page this desk could read.[8]

SOURCES Every event here was re-verified on its promoter's, venue's or official ticketing page on 13 November 2026; quoted wording is theirs. **SISTIC is gated to this desk — its events page renders "0 results found" — so every Singapore entry is confirmed off a venue or promoter page instead, which is the better source anyway.** 1 christmaswonderland.sg's own ticket page for the full band table, and Gardens by the Bay's own page for the Train Show — **which still gives no Flower Dome figure, a seventh issue of asking resolved on one of the two.** 2 nationalgallery.sg's own exhibition pages for both shows, the discount window and the 180-day validity. 3 Esplanade's own festival listings for both festivals and every price quoted. 4 artsg.com/tickets for every tier and the deadline. 5 thekallang.com.sg's own event page for the price bands and the September sale dates. 6 sumo.pia.jp's English sales schedule, **read at source**, for both tournaments and the Fukuoka sold-out status. 7 mori.art.museum's own exhibitions page and the Roppongi Hills art-view information page for all three shows and every yen figure. 8 **Omitted for want of a primary read, and named so the omission is auditable:** the Sapporo Snow Festival, the ArtScience Museum, Singapore Art Week, Huayi and teamLab.

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW SINGAPORE ROOMS

Casa Vostra opened in Wisma Atria on Thursday and takes no bookings until December

Antonio Miscellaneo's fourth outlet seats 85 and sells crisp square pizza slices at S$15. Two older rooms now have verdicts: a twelve-seat udon counter, and a butcher with a thirty-person queue.

Casa Vostra opened its fourth and largest branch in Wisma Atria on or about Thursday 12 November, with 85 seats and a format exclusive to this room: square crisp-based pizza slices at S$15 in three flavours — tomato tarte tatin, zucchini and sakura-ebi, and potato with leek and speck. Chef-owner Antonio Miscellaneo also runs La Bottega Enoteca; the earlier outlets are at Raffles City, Jem and Tampines Mall. Orecchiette with sausage and broccoli is S$22; ossobuco S$30.[1]

Too new to judge, and this desk means it literally: the room opened yesterday and not one review of it exists. No Eatbook, no SETHLUI, no Time Out, no Michelin notice; Chope has no listing. The earlier branches are well regarded, but that is the brand, not this room. Reservations do not open until December and then only a fortnight ahead, most tables held for walk-ins — so the only play is 11.30am on a weekday.[1]

The verdicts belong to two rooms this book first listed in No. 153, eight issues ago. **Nekobushi Udon**, ten counter seats and two tables in Orchard Plaza with no signboard at the door, sells exactly two bowls: kitsune at S$14.80, in a dashi of bonito, sardine, mackerel, flying fish and kombu, and gyu at S$18.80 with beef short rib and crisp wagyu intestine. The Ranting Panda scored it 3.5 out of 5 in October and wrote the verdict plainly: "Worth a try, though I am hoping more dishes or seasonal flavours are introduced in due course to warrant a return visit." The praise is for the simmered tofu; the reservation is the two-item menu. Online seats sold out almost immediately and remain scarce. Sunday lunch, 11.30 to 2.45, is the softest slot.[2]

Woodsmen by Cut Butchery in Thomson Plaza is the one with evidence behind it: a butchery counter and a live tank at the front, a wood-fired kitchen at the back, no cooking fee and no service charge, and a posted warning to expect minimal service. Marble-score-four ribeye is S$13 per 100g on weekday promotions, A5 wagyu S$38. Two blogs, no food-magazine notice: The Ranting Panda gave it 4 out of 5 in October — "unpretentious and casual… without the fuss", the cheddar cloud fries "a bit soggy"; Ordinary Patrons judged the economics "a fair deal". **Thirty people were queuing on a Friday night**, and bookings are taken only for parties of eight.[3]

WALK-IN ONLY | TOO NEW TO CALL | VERDICT RUN

THE BUZZ · WHAT CASA VOSTRA AND THE OTHER THREE HAVE EARNED

The honest ledger for these four rooms is: one unreviewed, one reviewed once, one reviewed twice by blogs, and one not reviewed at all. **Ma Cuisinette** is the fourth — a father-and-son French stall in a food hall at Far East Plaza, chicken Provençale S$9, mussels in cream S$12.90. Alain Perez, 35, trained at the Lycée Hôtelier de Toulouse and was an aircraft technician for six years first; his father Laurent, 60, writes the dishes. Its November profile is filed under people, not openings, and carries no verdict. **And it is not new: the stall opened in May, so this is a discovery, printed as one.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THIS TABLE WAS PICKED FROM AN EXHAUSTED PIPELINE

Four rooms is what survived, and the reader should know why. This book bars a venue after two runs, and the barred list holds **139** names. Against this fortnight's openings that bar is close to total: eleven of twelve in one local round-up were already barred, four of six in another. So two of these four are second runs on rooms first listed in No. 153, one is a day old, one is six months old. **The second gap:** no social or forum sentiment appears on this page, because Reddit, Burpple, SETHLUI, Time Out and the Michelin guide all refused this desk today. That is an absence of access, not of chatter, and it is not dressed up as consensus.[5]

SOURCES 1 HungryGoWhere's announcement of 12 November 2026, **read at source** — an announcement, not a review, and labelled so on the page. 2 The Ranting Panda's review of 16 October 2026 and its November round-up, both **read at source**; the score and the verdict are quoted as written. 3 The Ranting Panda, 11 October 2026, and Ordinary Patrons, 31 August 2026, both **read at source**; the queue figure and the eight-person booking rule are from the first. 4 HungryGoWhere, 6 November 2026, **read at source**, which states the stall launched in May. 5 This book's own table ledger for the 139 barred names; the four local round-ups checked are Eatbook's November list, The Ranting Panda's November scoops, and Honeycombers' and HungryGoWhere's November openings. **Refused this desk today, each named so the gap is auditable:** Reddit in every form, Burpple, SETHLUI, Time Out Singapore, 8days, the Michelin Guide, Daniel Food Diary and Eatbook's category pages. **Also dropped:** a genuine November opening whose name carries a barred venue's, and four rooms rejected on age after checking their first-review dates.

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN'S SCHOOL CLUBS

Japan is evicting the school club from the school, and Kobe went first

A six-year statutory period began in April 2026. On 1 September Kobe replaced about 1,100 school clubs with 1,007 licensed private ones; families there now pay about ¥3,200 a month.

In almost every Japanese junior high school, the thing that actually raised the children was not the lessons. It was the club — the baseball team, the brass band, the calligraphy room — run after school and at weekends by teachers who were not paid for it. Japan has now decided it can no longer afford that arrangement, and is handing the clubs to licensed outside organisations that charge families a monthly fee.[1]

The reason is written in labour law, not education policy. An amendment passed in 2025 commits the government to cutting teachers' average monthly overtime inside school to about thirty hours by the 2029 financial year, and lists among its instruments "financial assistance to smoothly advance the regional deployment of club activities". A second 2025 amendment, to the Basic Act on Sport, gives local authorities a brand-new duty: to secure opportunities for junior-high pupils to enjoy sport *in the community*, in cooperation with residents' own sports bodies. The club was not reformed. It was reassigned.[2]

The policy's own name tells you how carefully this is being done. Until 2023 it was **地域移行** — *chiiki ikō*, "transfer to the community". The ministry changed it to **地域展開**, *chiiki tenkai*, "regional deployment", because "transfer" frightened people. In the same documents the child acquires a new noun: **受益者**, *jueki-sha*, the beneficiary — as in *jueki-sha futan*, beneficiary-pays.[3]

And the price of a Japanese adolescence is now written down. In a December 2025 budget annex the Sports Agency gave an "image" of what a family should expect to pay for activity about four days a month at weekends: **¥1,000 to ¥3,000 a month**, with anything from a few hundred yen to about ¥4,000 permitted, and a municipality free to charge nothing and fund it wholly from public money. Kobe, which has gone furthest, has discovered the market price. Its average club membership fee is about **¥3,200**.[4]

What the ministry is doing is not abolition, and this essay will not claim it is. School clubs continue; the guideline caps them at about eleven hours a week; in mountainous and island districts the instruction is explicitly to post paid coaches rather than force a transition; and Inagi City, in Tokyo, states flatly on its own English pages that it will keep school-based clubs and strengthen outside coaching instead. The national machine is nonetheless enormous. Against a stated denominator of **128,000** school clubs, the share of weekend clubs already deployed to the community went from **5.6 per cent** in the 2023 financial year to **17.5** in 2025, with **38.2 per cent** planned for 2027.[5]

The club did not leave the building. It left the balance sheet.

94.2%

OF THESE "COMMUNITY" CLUBS MEET IN THE SCHOOL

THE NUMBER NOBODY PUBLISHED · JAPAN CUT ITS OWN CLUB FORECAST

Compare two editions of the same official survey. The 2025 edition projected that weekend deployment would reach **30.4 per cent**, or 38,954 clubs, in the 2026 financial year. The 2026 edition records the 2026 plan as **27.8 per cent**, or 35,613. The forecast was cut by **2.6 points and 3,341 clubs** in twelve months, and no release says so. The 2025 year itself came in slightly ahead of plan; it is the future that is being revised down. Municipalities, asked what is hardest, put a sustainable revenue structure first at **16.2 per cent**, finding enough coaches second at **15.9**, and getting parents and children to accept the fee third at **14.1**.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Sports Agency and Agency for Cultural Affairs' comprehensive guideline of December 2025 and its reference annex, **read at source as published Japanese-language documents**. 2 The annex reproduces both statutes: the supplementary provisions of the amended teachers' salary law, carrying the thirty-hour target for the 2029 financial year and its measure (6); and Article 17-2 of the Basic Act on Sport as amended in 2025. **Both read at source in the ministry's own annex.** 3 The ministry's own bulletins, which still write *chiiki tenkai*; the renaming from *ikō* is visible in the documents' own sequence. 4 The Sports Agency's frequently-asked-questions document on the new guideline, current as of 31 March 2026, question 11, **read at source**, for the December 2025 budget annex figures; Kobe's own figure as reported below. 5 The Sports Agency's progress survey, fielded 22 April to 22 May 2026 and published that August, and its predecessor fielded in 2025 — **both read at source as the ministry's own published returns**; the 128,000 denominator is an assumption stated in the survey's own footnote rather than a count, and is printed as such.

Kobe is the test case because it did the whole thing at once. From 1 September 2026 its municipal junior highs stopped running club activities altogether — weekdays included — the first of Japan's designated cities to go that far. Against roughly 1,100 school clubs, the city certified **1,007** outside ones across three recruitment rounds, 534 in the first and 473 in the second. Eighty-two public junior highs now point their pupils at a licensed market.[1]

The city has been careful with money in a way that tells you what it expects to go wrong. It subsidises **¥1,500** a month per pupil, and **¥3,000** for households on school-attendance aid, paid as points in an application; for September 2026 to March 2027 that comes to **¥10,500**. It pays the **¥800**-a-year insurance premium for each child — a child who used to be insured by being at school. It has set up a **one-billion-yen** support fund, into which a local company has donated two million yen towards replacing exercise equipment and wind instruments, and it has passed what it describes as Japan's first municipal ordinance on community club activities. Activity is capped at about two hours on a weekday inside a 4pm-to-8.30pm window, three at weekends, five days a week.[1]

Here is the fact that makes the whole policy legible. In **94.2 per cent** of municipalities running these clubs, the main venue is the junior high school's own facilities. The gym is the same gym. Often the coach is the same teacher, now moonlighting for pay under a dual-employment permit. What changes is legal status: a certification, an insurance policy, a membership contract, published accounts, and a fee. The club did not leave the building. It left the balance sheet.[2]

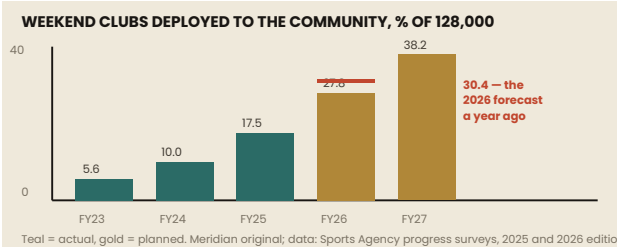
The certification is the machinery, and it is genuinely demanding. To be a **認定地域クラブ活動** — a certified community club — an operator must admit anyone without selection, cap sessions at two hours on weekdays and three at weekends, give at least two rest days a week, keep fees "as low as possible" against the national benchmark, register and train its coaches, screen them through Japan's new child-safeguarding records check, insure both participants and coaches, publish its rules and accounts, and not be primarily for profit. In return it gets public money, priority booking and fee waivers on the school gym, permission to employ the school's own teachers, and — the part that decides everything — "smooth participation in competitions". The transitional grace period ends on **31 March 2027**.[3]

Because that is the other half of the mechanism: the licence, not the school, is becoming the gate to the national stage. From the 2027 financial year the Japan Junior High School Athletic Federation drops **nine sports** from its national championship — swimming, handball, gymnastics, rhythmic gymnastics, boys' softball, sumo, skiing, skating and ice hockey — leaving eleven summer sports and no winter meet at all. The criterion was a club-installation rate below **20 per cent**. The targets: each sport inside three days, participants down **30 per cent**, costs down **30**. The reasons given were falling pupil numbers, summer heat, and the burden on the teachers who run the meet. The swimming federation protested that this is the only national championship its age group has, and that it was first consulted in March 2024, when continuation was still being discussed.[4]

A Japanese child can no longer swim, vault or skate for a national schools title.

1,007

CLUBS KOBE LICENSED TO REPLACE ABOUT 1,100



The red mark is the forecast for this year as it stood twelve months ago: 2.6 points and 3,341 clubs higher than the plan now says.

SOURCES 1 Kyodo, via Kumanichi, 31 August 2026, for the 1 September cessation and the designated-city first; Kobe City's own release of 16 June 2026 and its policy-meeting paper of 1 September 2025 for the club counts, the recruitment rounds, the subsidy and points scheme, the insurance premium, the fund, the ordinance claim and the activity windows — **all read at source**; SoraNews24, 6 September 2026, for the eighty-two schools. **The formal title of Kobe's ordinance is held: the city's server reset on the document that carries it.** 2 The Sports Agency's progress survey, 2025 edition, **read at source** — 94.2 per cent of 1,062 responding municipalities name the junior high school's own facilities as the main venue. 3 The Sports Agency's own certification summary sheet of February 2026 and the guideline's question-and-answer document, **both read at source**, for every requirement, every benefit and the 31 March 2027 grace date. 4 Daily Sports, 8 June 2024, **read at source**, for the nine sports, the 20 per cent criterion, the three reduction targets, the stated reasons and the swimming federation's protest.

Whether this is a loss depends on who could already afford to play, and Japan has the data. In January 2025 the Sasakawa Sports Foundation surveyed **3,136** parents: a year in a school sports club costs a household **¥50,857**, a year in a private one **¥155,799**. Among households under four million yen a year, **42.3 per cent** of children were in a school club, against above half in every other band.[1]

The barriers those parents name are precisely the two things the new system adds. Among parents whose child plays no sport, "costs make it too hard" was given by **52.1 per cent** in the bottom band against **18.1** at the top, and "the driving and the parent duties make it too hard" by **59.5** against **29.8**. The school club was the one sports provision in Japan that poor families actually used, and what replaces it is the thing they already could not afford or could not reach.[1]

Niigata City has measured what that feels like. In May 2026 it asked its junior-high parents and got **6,658** replies: **53.0 per cent** of children were in a community club and **44.6** in none at all. Of the 1,938 who wrote free text, the largest cluster was views on the transition itself, then the old club, then transport, then coaches. Parents wrote that practice times and venues were unstable; that a community club and a school club differ in principle, because the club was where a child was formed inside a group; that if a parent must drive on a weekday there is no difference between this and a commercial team. One had heard nothing about the volleyball arrangements and learned about the money from their own child.[2]

The city's analysis concedes four failures in its own words: confusion over the transition, a shift of freed time into phones, games and video, a heavier driving burden, and a decline in exercise — and says the dominant cause is simply that the club has gone. Kobe found the same problem geographically: in its thin north-western wards the schools are too far apart and the buses too sparse.[2]

America ran the experiment first, which is the nearest thing to a forecast available. After budget cuts, a national children's-health poll conducted in January 2012 found a pay-to-play fee charged for **61 per cent** of school-sports participants, averaging **$93**, with only **6 per cent** getting a waiver; a third of lower-income parents said their child played school sports against more than half of higher-income ones. Japan has its own precedent too: long-term care insurance, from April 2000, took an unpaid household duty and made it a certified, means-assessed, co-paid service bought from licensed providers. It put a price on something that had never had one.[3]

Which leaves the honest gap. **Nobody has published what Japanese families are actually paying.** The state published an "image", Kobe an average; there is no national figure for realised fees by sport, municipality or income band, and no count of children who stopped because of a fee. The strongest critique in Japan is not that the policy is wrong but that it is uniform: Miyamoto Sachiko of the Sasakawa foundation argues that deployment is only a means to a better environment for children, and that the effect on low-income children must be weighed every time higher contributions are discussed.[4]

The teachers, it should be said, are winning: their weekend hours on clubs fell from two hours nine minutes a day in 2016 to one hour twenty-nine in 2022, the largest reduction of any task they do. Still, **6.9 per cent** run clubs six or more days a week, in breach of the guideline. The old system ran on uncompensated labour, and the guideline devotes a section to eradicating the violence and harassment that unpaid, unscreened coaching produced. Insurance, training, record checks and a three-hour cap are improvements. That is what makes this a hard story rather than a sad one: the reform is real, the gain is real, and the bill is going to the households least able to pay it. Japan is discovering what the cost of adolescence was, by being made to put it on an invoice.[5]

The state priced a Japanese adolescence at ¥1,000 to ¥3,000 a month, in a budget annex.

SOURCES 1 Sasakawa Sports Foundation, "Survey on junior-high pupils' sports activity and parental involvement", fielded January 2025, n = 3,136 parents, released 12 November 2025 — **its own release read at source** for every yen figure, every income-band percentage and every driving figure. 2 Niigata City's own parent survey of May 2026, published by its community-club office — **the full return read at source**, including the free-text cluster counts and the city's own four-point self-assessment; Kobe City's policy-meeting minutes of 1 September 2025 for the north-western access problem and the shared-taxi trial. **Parents' words are summarised from the city's own published verbatims and are not presented as quotations.** 3 The C.S. Mott Children's Hospital National Poll on Children's Health, volume 15 number 3, published 14 May 2012 on polling conducted that January — **the report read at source as a PDF. The long-term-care-insurance comparison is this desk's own, drawn from the general public record rather than re-read today, and is offered as an analogy rather than a sourced claim.** 4 Miyamoto Sachiko, senior policy director, in the Sasakawa release of 12 November 2025, **read at source**; her co-researcher is Nakazawa Atsushi of Waseda. 5 Japan's Ministry of Education teacher working-hours survey for the 2022 financial year, **read at source**, for the weekend reduction and the 6.9 per cent; the Sports Agency's progress survey for the 81.3 and 90.1 per cent; the December 2025 guideline for the section on eradicating violence and harassment. **Held and not printed:** how many teachers nationally hold a dual-employment permit and what they are paid, which is unpublished; whether high-school admissions genuinely treat the two kinds of club alike, which the guideline instructs and nobody audits; and the ridership and cost of Kobe's shared-taxi trial.

THE LAST WORD

Whose name is on it

Emerson's line about the institution being one man's lengthened shadow was meant as praise. Read this issue back and it reads as a warning. Nvidia went thirty-three years without a chair of its board because it did not need one; it had a founder. On Wednesday it needed one overnight — while the filing that removed the founder gave no reason, no disagreement and no terms (p3).

The same gap runs through the book. A company at Collyer Quay with a locked door and a managing director who left holding one share bought for a dollar (p5). A tariff written to keep dangerous things out, used to let them through at a quarter of their value (p7). A kettle sold as Nambu ironware and cast in Osaka (p6).

And then Japan, which has done the thing most precisely. The club meets in the same gym, at the same hour, often with the same teacher — 94.2 per cent of these "community" clubs are held in the school they left. What changed is a certificate, an insurance policy and an invoice for about three thousand two hundred yen a month (p21). The ministry even changed the word: not *transfer*, which frightened people, but *deployment*.

None of these is a lie. Every one is disclosed somewhere — in a filing, a budget annex, a government page — to somebody. That is the uncomfortable part. The name on the door is rarely false; it is just not where the work is done, and finding out where takes a reader who goes and looks. Which is, more or less, the job.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 161 · 13 November 2026

A note on method. Read at source this edition: Nvidia's Form 8-K of 12 November on EDGAR, line by line, and its exhibit; the Wyden–Neal letter to the commerce secretary in full as a PDF; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October release, including its statement that no twelve-month inflation rate exists; Emerson's "Self-Reliance" in the Project Gutenberg text; Japan's Sports Agency guideline, its certification sheet and two editions of its progress survey; the Sasakawa foundation's income-gradient release and Niigata City's own parent survey; Oigen's and Iwachu's own pages in Japanese; Scan's and Framework's live listings; Samsung's own eyewear release; eight venue and promoter pages for The Diary; *Nature Medicine*'s tirzepatide trial in full; and six further journal records. **Refused this desk, and said so on the page each time:** Reddit in every form, all build — which is why no forum sentiment appears outside Hacker News and HardwareZone; Reuters, the Associated Press, the New York Times and the Wall Street Journal; the Straits Times, Channel NewsAsia and the Business Times; the Home Affairs Ministry's own media room; CME's rate tool; WatchUSeek, now behind a payment wall; teaforum; Casio's own pages; Marina Bay Sands; and Wikimedia Commons, which rate-limited one image out of this issue. **Held rather than printed:** Brent crude, on which three sources disagreed by thirteen dollars; the Iranian mine claims in full; Christmas Wonderland's Flower Dome companion price; Japan's traditional-craft designation rule; and what Japanese families actually pay. **Corrected:** *Godzilla Minus Zero*'s American opening, which No. 160 gave as $30,612,674 and Box Office Mojo now gives as $30,628,265 (p11).